POLITICS | Monologues

IDEAS OF INDIA: On Ambedkar and inclusion

SHASHI THAROOR *Congress MP, former Union minister, ex-diplomat and author*

BATTLE OF BELONGING

Congress MP Shashi Tharoor says he marvels at our pluralist democracy and the changes we have witnessed in the past 75 years and how we have sustained ourselves. He calls it a 'battle of belonging', a civic nationalism not anchored in timeless severities handed down from birth but one anchored in our Constitution and in the country's institutions. But today, Tharoor feels the national discourse has been injected with a toxin of hatred for minorities in general, and one minority in particular. He feels the ruling government has condoned this othering of a significant portion of our population, an exclusion he feels is profoundly anti-Hindu. He also touched on topics such as the 'misleading' minority appeasement charges and Hindutva votaries coopting national icons such as Vivekananda and Ambedkar, who were quite critical about the idea of majoritarian rule. Tharoor also said that Ambedkar was the subject of his recent book, and went on to expound on the Dalit icon. ■

In a large and diverse democracy like ours, you don't need to agree all the time as long as you agree on the ground rules of how you will disagree

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We all want to see our country growing in both the hardware of development and the software of it, the hardware being the infrastructure... and the software, the precious human capital



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KEY TAKEAWAYS

- India's democracy holds up pluralism as its ideal for it sees diversity as our strength
- Charges of minority appeasement and pampering fly in the face of basic facts
- Vivekananda taught us that our pride as Hindus cannot come at the expense of another community
- The Constitution says one person, one vote but we have a society where one person does not have the same value as another